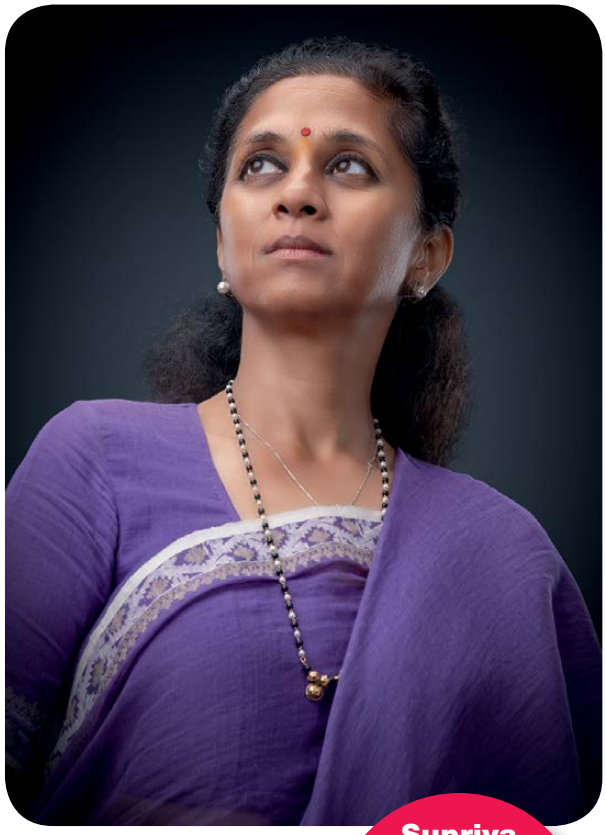
AN ELEGANT HEIR



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

Supriya Sule, *54*
Lok Sabha MP, Baramati; Working President, NCP (Sharad Pawar faction)

SUPRIYA SULE CARRIES HERSELF WITH A poise adorned with humility—endowed as she is with a calm, non-threatening demeanour. But no one would have thought it odd had it not been so. As the daughter of Maratha strongman Sharad Pawar, she could have just as easily accessorised the sense of entitled arrogance political legatees often exude. Ironically, her cousin Ajit Pawar, original heir apparent to the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) estate, is often charged with being cast in that bratish mould. The negotiation between that duality—politically fraught but never shorn of filial warmth—plays out as a fascinating drama in the heart of Maharashtra's ever-evolving political landscape. It's a riddle vital to 2024. Ajit, having splintered off a goodish part of the NCP, is now deputy CM in a BJP-ordained regime. The uncle, always good at conversing beyond ideological barriers, is not short of overtures from the nephew while being central to the INDIA bloc architecture. And Supriya seems a natural-born citizen on the other side, often seen sororising with women Opposition MPs, standing in solidarity with the women wrestlers who dared to protest, joining Rahul Gandhi as the Bharat Jodo Yatra passed through Nanded, gently ticking off Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma for picking up misogyny from the BJP after his jibe that Pawar Sr should "send Supriya to Gaza to fight for Hamas".

Alongside, silently, she has watered her roots well. After a Rajya Sabha debut in 2006, father let daughter take Baramati in the 2009 LS polls: admittedly, an author-backed role. But she held on tenaciously, bucking the Modi wave in 2014 to humble a BJP-backed rival by some 70,000 votes. And in 2019, the mother of two (husband Sadanand is a businessman) more than doubled her margin against the BJP. Evidently, her ease with the jet-set carries over to rustic farmers in her constituency. Pawar may want to see her scale that up to be Maharashtra's first woman CM. Time for some old-style Maratha valour? ■

–Dhaval S. Kulkarni

ACCOMPLISHMENT

Three Lok Sabha poll wins in a climate not always salubrious. Now she has to fight to revivify the legacy of father Sharad Pawar

AS PER THE...

"I never advise others. But the best advice I have got is to pause, evaluate, respond (PER), never react. In a negotiation or a conversation, I always follow PER"

↘ ALL THE ALLIES

"I have a huge friends' circle. People matter to me. I have friends in every city. They are my strength and my weakness"

↘ YUM FACTOR

Favourite food is bajari chi bhakri and thecha. Loves pizza and cheese too